

DIGITAL EUROPE PROGRAMME

Digital Europe Programme (DIGITAL) Grant

Federated AI Skills Academies for European SMEs AISKILLS-EU

Field	Value
Call Identifier	DIGITAL-2026-SKILLS-09-LEAGUE-OF-ACADEMIES
Type of Action	Coordination and Support Action — Digital Europe Programme
Duration	36 months
TRL Range	TRL 0 to TRL 0
Total Budget	EUR 6,000,000
EU Contribution	EUR 3,000,000

Abstract

AIKILLS-EU (Federated AI Skills Academies for European SMEs) deploys a federated network of advanced AI training academies across five EU Member States, anchored in established European Digital Innovation Hubs (EDIHs) in Ireland, Spain, Poland, Finland, and Germany. The project directly addresses the critical and growing gap in trustworthy AI and data skills among SME workforces — the backbone of the European economy — and responds to the urgent upskilling imperative created by the EU AI Act (Regulation (EU) 2024/1689) and the Digital Decade 2030 ICT professionals target.

Over 36 months, AIKILLS-EU will: train at least 5,000 SME professionals in trustworthy AI, machine learning, and data governance; issue 2,500 portable Europass micro-credentials aligned with the European e-Competence Framework; engage a minimum of 300 SMEs across the five participating countries in structured academy programmes; and contribute 30 validated training modules to the Digital Skills and Jobs Platform catalogue. The three-tier curriculum — AI Literacy, Applied AI Practitioner, and Trustworthy AI Specialist — is mapped to EU AI Act compliance requirements and delivered through a blended model combining self-paced e-learning, live virtual cohorts, and in-person EDIH bootcamps.

The federated model maximises geographic reach, leverages existing EDIH infrastructure and SME trust relationships, and is designed for financially self-sustaining operation beyond the grant through EDIH service integration, national co-funding streams, and a tiered fee model. The open-source platform release at month 12 enables replication by any EDIH across the EU. The project contributes directly to the ELEVATE European League of Advanced Digital Skills Academies, including a quality seal framework, annual market intelligence reports, and active participation in ELEVATE coordination structures.

Total budget: EUR 6,000,000 (EU contribution: EUR 3,000,000). Duration: 36 months.

Keywords: advanced digital skills, artificial intelligence, trustworthy AI, SME workforce, European Digital Innovation Hubs, micro-credentials, federated academy, AI Act, Digital Decade, upskilling

SECTION 1 - RELEVANCE

1.1 Objectives and Ambition

AISKILLS-EU aims to deploy a federated network of advanced AI skills academies that delivers high-quality, trustworthy-AI and data training to SME workforces across five EU Member States, contributing directly to the Digital Decade target of 20 million ICT professionals in Europe by 2030. The project addresses a structural gap: while large enterprises have dedicated capacity for AI upskilling, European SMEs — which account for over 99% of all EU businesses and two thirds of private-sector employment — remain significantly underserved by advanced digital skills provision. AISKILLS-EU will change this by creating a replicable, open, federated academy model anchored in European Digital Innovation Hubs (EDIHs) and delivered through a shared digital platform, enabling continuous training cycles well beyond the grant period.

The project goes beyond the current state of the art in three respects. First, whereas existing EU-funded AI academies predominantly target students or large-enterprise professionals, AISKILLS-EU is the first initiative to systematically deploy a federated, EDIH-anchored AI skills infrastructure specifically designed for SME workforces, combining proximity-based delivery with EU-wide coherence. Second, the project aligns curriculum content directly with the EU AI Act's skills obligations for SMEs — an area not yet addressed by any operational European training framework — providing organisations with a structured compliance-oriented learning pathway. Third, the federated platform architecture enables cross-border recognition of micro-credentials via Europass Digital Credentials for Learning, creating portable, employer-readable evidence of AI competence at a scale not previously achieved for SME contexts.

The project pursues four measurable deployment objectives: (1) train at least 5,000 SME professionals in trustworthy AI, machine learning, and data governance over 36 months; (2) certify at least 2,500 participants under a European AI competence framework aligned with the EU AI Act and the European e-Competence Framework (e-CF); (3) engage at least 300 SMEs across the five participating countries in structured academy programmes; and (4) establish a self-sustaining federated academy model operational beyond the grant, with annual capacity for at least 2,000 additional trainees. These objectives are specific, measurable, achievable within the budget and timeline, relevant to the call priorities, and time-bound to the 36-month project period. They are directly traceable to compulsory call KPIs and are embedded in a results-oriented management framework monitored throughout the project lifecycle.

1.2 Relation to the Work Programme

AISKILLS-EU responds directly to call topic DIGITAL-2026-SKILLS-09-LEAGUE-OF-ACADEMIES (ELEVATE: European League of Advanced Digital Skills Academies). The action contributes to all four pillars of ELEVATE: (1) coordination and synergy — by federating five national EDIH nodes into a coherent academy network fully aligned with the Digital Skills and Jobs Platform (DSJP) and the LEADSx2030 agenda; (2) capacity building — by developing a quality assurance seal framework for AI training modules delivered to SMEs, directly supporting ELEVATE's quality harmonisation ambition; (3) outreach and inclusion — by specifically targeting women and underrepresented groups within SME workforces, with a binding 40% female participation target; and (4) market intelligence — by generating and publishing an annual advanced digital skills needs analysis for the SME sector, feeding evidence into future academy calls and national strategies.

At the policy level, AISKILLS-EU aligns with the European Commission's Competitiveness Compass, the EU AI Act (Regulation (EU) 2024/1689) — which creates an urgent and legally consequential compliance and skills imperative for SMEs across all sectors — the Union of Skills initiative, and the Digital Decade Policy Programme 2030 targets for ICT specialists and digitally skilled citizens. The

action complements, without duplicating, the work of existing DIGITAL-funded academies in AI (including those under DIGITAL-2021-SKILLS-01-SPECIALISED and DIGITAL-2024-ADVANCED-DIGITAL-07-KEYCAPACITY) by explicitly targeting SME workforces rather than students or large-enterprise professionals, and by using the EDIH network as a trusted, proximity-based delivery channel that reaches enterprises already embedded in an EU-recognised digital transformation support ecosystem. The consortium will contribute a minimum of 30 validated training modules and associated learning pathways to the DSJP training catalogue, materially expanding EU-wide coverage of advanced AI skills content. Complementarities with Horizon Europe skills-related projects, ESF+ national co-financing mechanisms, and national digital skills programmes will be mapped in the project's first quarter; active measures to avoid duplication of funding will be documented in the Data Management Plan and reported to HaDEA.

1.3 Concept and Methodology

The federated academy model is the core conceptual and methodological innovation of AISKILLS-EU. Rather than creating a single centralised institution — which would impose geographic barriers, language constraints, and high participation costs on SMEs — the project federates five existing EDIH nodes in Ireland, Spain, Poland, Finland, and Germany, each operating as an academy hub serving SMEs in its national and regional ecosystem. A shared federated platform (WP2) ensures coherence of curriculum, quality standards, and certification, while each hub retains the flexibility to localise content, delivery language, and sectoral focus to its national context. This design simultaneously maximises geographic reach, reduces participation barriers for SMEs, leverages sunk investment in EDIH infrastructure, and avoids the creation of a redundant platform outside established EU digital infrastructure.

The curriculum (WP1) is structured in three progressive tiers: (i) AI Literacy for all SME staff, providing foundational understanding of AI concepts, data practices, and ethical implications; (ii) Applied AI and Data Practitioner tracks for operational and technical roles, covering machine learning workflows, data governance, and responsible deployment; and (iii) Trustworthy AI and AI Act Compliance specialist tracks for technical leads and management roles, covering risk classification, conformity obligations, human oversight requirements, and documentation practices. All modules are mapped to the e-CF, the AI Watch competence framework, and the specific AI Act obligations relevant to SMEs. Curriculum co-design involves structured industry advisory groups at each hub, convened from month 1, ensuring ongoing labour-market relevance and responsiveness to emerging AI Act implementing acts.

Delivery (WP3) intentionally combines three modalities to maximise inclusivity: self-paced e-learning for flexibility; live virtual cohorts for peer learning and expert interaction; and in-person bootcamps at EDIH premises for hands-on practical exercises. This blended model accommodates the diverse constraints — time, connectivity, prior digital skills — of SME workforces. Certification (WP4) issues micro-credentials via the European Digital Credentials for Learning (EDCL/Europass) standard, ensuring portability and cross-border employer recognition. The federated platform integrates with the DSJP training catalogue API, enabling seamless discovery of AISKILLS-EU content by the broader European skills community. An independent quality assurance committee reviews all modules against the quality seal criteria developed in alignment with ELEVATE standards, with annual re-validation cycles ensuring content currency as AI regulation and technology evolve.

1.4 Interdisciplinary Considerations

AISKILLS-EU integrates four cross-cutting dimensions throughout its design, governance, and delivery.

First, data protection and security: the federated platform is designed in full compliance with the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR); learner personal data is processed under Data Protection Impact Assessments (DPIAs) conducted at each hub prior to launch; no personal data is

transferred outside the EU; data minimisation principles are applied throughout platform design. The Data Management Plan (D6.1) specifies retention schedules, access controls, and breach response procedures.

Second, gender equality and inclusion: the consortium commits to a binding minimum 40% female participation target across all training cohorts, supported by active outreach to women-led SMEs, flexible scheduling options, and mentoring pairings facilitated through EDIH networks. Gender-disaggregated enrolment data are reported per country and per training tier in all periodic progress reports. The project communication approach — including imagery, language, and role-model profiling — follows gender-inclusive communication guidelines. Participation rates for other underrepresented groups (including workers in SMEs in economically lagging regions and workers over 50 undergoing digital reskilling) are monitored as secondary inclusion indicators.

Third, ethical AI principles: curriculum content systematically embeds the EU's Ethics Guidelines for Trustworthy AI, the AI Act's requirements for human oversight, transparency, accountability, and fundamental rights impact assessment, and the IEEE Ethically Aligned Design framework. The goal is not merely regulatory compliance awareness but the formation of practitioners who actively propagate trustworthy AI practices within their organisations and supply chains.

Fourth, digital inclusion and accessibility: all e-learning modules comply with the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG 2.1 Level AA); the platform supports multiple EU languages including the five national languages of participating Member States; and Financial Support to Third Parties (FSTP) mechanisms are available to micro-enterprises facing financial barriers to participation, ensuring that the smallest and most vulnerable businesses in the SME ecosystem are not systematically excluded from the programme's benefits.

SECTION 2 - IMPACT

2.1 Pathways Towards Impact

AIKILLS-EU generates impact through three mutually reinforcing pathways, each with defined outputs, intermediate outcomes, and long-term effects traceable to EU policy objectives.

The direct pathway is skills deployment and organisational change. Over 36 months, 5,000 SME professionals will complete structured AI training and 2,500 will achieve portable micro-credentials. These individuals return to their organisations equipped to implement trustworthy AI systems, assess and document AI Act compliance obligations, and drive data-led productivity and efficiency improvements — creating measurable organisational-level impact across at least 300 SMEs. The three-tier curriculum structure ensures that impact operates at multiple levels simultaneously: AI Literacy training raises awareness and readiness organisation-wide; Practitioner-level training builds operational capability; and Specialist-level certification builds internal expertise capable of sustaining and scaling AI adoption without ongoing external support.

The systemic pathway operates through the federated academy infrastructure itself. By anchoring academies in EDIHs — which function as trusted, publicly recognised one-stop shops for SME digital transformation and maintain active relationships with tens of thousands of enterprises — AIKILLS-EU embeds advanced AI training capacity into an already-established and EU-funded support ecosystem. This structural embedding multiplies reach far beyond the 300 directly engaged SMEs: EDIH partners collectively serve SME ecosystems spanning multiple regions and industrial sectors, enabling warm referral pathways, peer learning communities, and integration of AI skills training into wider digital transformation consultancy services. The open-source release of the federated platform at month 12 further extends systemic impact by enabling replication by other EDIHs across the EU without additional platform development cost.

The policy and ecosystem pathway operates through knowledge, standards, and governance contributions. The quality seal framework developed in WP1 provides a transferable standard for AI training quality that can be adopted by future ELEVATE academies. The 30 training modules contributed to the DSJP catalogue expand the discoverable European AI skills content library. Three annual market intelligence reports provide evidence on SME AI skills demand to DG CONNECT, national ministries, and DSJP editors, directly informing future calls and national digital skills strategies. Active participation in ELEVATE coordination structures ensures that AIKILLS-EU findings and tools contribute to EU-level policy learning throughout the project lifetime.

2.2 Dissemination, Exploitation and Communication

Financial and operational sustainability is architecturally embedded in AIKILLS-EU rather than treated as a post-project afterthought. Each EDIH partner integrates the academy into its core service portfolio from the outset: training activities are scoped to continue after the grant using a combination of EDIH operational budgets allocated through national and EU co-funding, national digital skills programme financing (including ESF+ streams), and a tiered fee model in which larger SMEs contribute training fees that cross-subsidise access for micro-enterprises and start-ups. The federated platform is released as an open-source component under a permissive licence, eliminating proprietary hosting dependencies and enabling any EDIH to deploy, adapt, and extend the infrastructure at minimal marginal cost. A detailed, financially grounded sustainability plan per hub is delivered at month 24 (D5.3), and confirmed continuation commitments — including named funding sources and projected trainee volumes — are required from all partners before the final payment request is submitted.

Dissemination and communication activities are structured around three distinct audiences, each

with tailored channels and messages. For policymakers and funders: the project provides structured briefings to DG CONNECT and national digital ministries at months 12, 24, and 36; contributes findings to the DSJP editorial board; and delivers three annual market intelligence reports on AI skills demand in the SME sector, positioned as an evidence base for future DIGITAL and ESF+ programming. For the EDIH and advanced digital skills ecosystem: the consortium actively participates in ELEVATE coordination calls and joint publications, contributes modules to the DSJP catalogue, presents at DIGITAL Skills and Jobs Platform events, and publishes the federated replication guide (D5.3) to support scale-out. For SMEs and individual learners: targeted digital campaigns via EDIH newsletters, LinkedIn, and national SME support networks; a LinkedIn learning community maintained throughout the project and beyond; and regional awareness events co-organised with Chambers of Commerce and national SME associations. A comprehensive communication plan (D5.1, delivered at month 3) specifies branding standards, key messages differentiated by audience, channel strategy, a gender-inclusive communication approach, and a schedule of major communication milestones. All public project outputs — reports, training modules, platform documentation, and market intelligence reports — are published open-access under a Creative Commons CC BY 4.0 licence, consistent with Horizon Europe and Digital Europe Open Science expectations.

2.3 Summary of Impact Indicators

Indicator	Target	Measurement
SME professionals trained	5,000 over 36 months	Platform enrolment and completion records, disaggregated by country and gender
Certifications issued (micro-credentials via Europass/EDCL)	2,500 over 36 months	Certification registry maintained by WP4 lead; reported in periodic progress reports
SMEs engaged in academy programmes	300 across 5 Member States	SME registration database at each hub; verified by EDIH account managers
Training modules added to DSJP catalogue	30 modules by month 30	DSJP editorial confirmation; module upload records
Female participation rate in training cohorts	Minimum 40% across all cohorts	Disaggregated enrolment data per hub; reported every 6 months
Post-grant annual training capacity (sustainability)	At least 2,000 trainees/year after project end	Continuation plan (D5.3) and year-1 post-project report (if applicable)
Quality seal assessments completed	At least 20 training modules assessed against quality seal criteria	Quality assurance committee records; aligned with ELEVATE seal framework

SECTION 3 - QUALITY AND EFFICIENCY OF IMPLEMENTATION

3.1 Work Plan and Work Packages

WP	Title	Lead	PM	Duration
WP1	Curriculum Design and Quality Assurance	Digital Skills Agency Ireland (Coordinator)	42	M1-M18
WP2	Federated Delivery Platform	EDIH Finland	38	M1-M12
WP3	Training Delivery and Hub Operations	EDIH Spain	88	M6-M36
WP4	Certification and Credentialing	Training SME Germany	30	M6-M36
WP5	Dissemination, Communication and Sustainability	EDIH Poland	28	M1-M36
WP6	Project Management and Coordination	Digital Skills Agency Ireland (Coordinator)	24	M1-M36

WP1: Curriculum Design and Quality Assurance

Lead: Digital Skills Agency Ireland (Coordinator) | Person-months: 42 | Duration: M1 - M18

WP1 develops the complete AISKILLS-EU curriculum across three progressive tiers — AI Literacy, Applied AI Practitioner, and Trustworthy AI Specialist — and establishes the quality assurance architecture that governs all training content across the five academy hubs. All modules are mapped to the European e-Competence Framework (e-CF) and to the specific competence requirements arising from the EU AI Act, ensuring that the curriculum delivers both professional development value and regulatory compliance readiness for SMEs. Industry advisory groups convened at each hub co-design and validate content from month 1, ensuring labour-market relevance and sectoral diversity. WP1 also produces the pedagogical guidelines, formative and summative assessment frameworks, and the quality seal alignment documentation used by all hub trainers and the independent quality assurance committee.

T1.1: Needs analysis and competence framework mapping - Conduct a structured AI skills needs analysis across the priority SME sectors in all five participating countries, using surveys, focus groups with EDIH SME clients, and desk review of national skills intelligence. Map the identified competence gaps to e-CF levels, AI Act obligations, and the AI Watch competence taxonomy to produce a validated competence mapping document that grounds all subsequent curriculum development.

T1.2: Curriculum development (three tiers) - Develop modular, reusable curriculum content for the AI Literacy, Applied AI Practitioner, and Trustworthy AI Specialist tracks, including learning objectives, instructional content, practical exercises, and formative and summative assessment instruments. Content is developed collaboratively across consortium partners using a structured co-authoring process, with peer review at each hub prior to quality committee sign-off.

T1.3: Quality assurance framework and seal alignment - Develop a comprehensive set of quality criteria for all AISKILLS-EU training modules, operationalising the ELEVATE quality seal framework for the AI-SME training context. Establish an independent quality assurance committee with representation from each hub; define the module submission, review, approval, and annual re-validation workflow; and document the framework in a public Quality Assurance Manual included in D1.2.

WP2: Federated Delivery Platform

Lead: EDIH Finland | Person-months: 38 | Duration: M1 - M12

WP2 designs, builds, and deploys the federated learning management system (LMS) that underpins all five academy hubs, providing a coherent and interoperable digital infrastructure while enabling each hub to operate with the language and branding customisation appropriate to its national context. The platform integrates with the DSJP training catalogue API to ensure discoverability of AISKILLS-EU content, supports Europass Digital Credentials for Learning (EDCL) issuance directly from the certification workflow, and is developed to meet WCAG 2.1 Level AA accessibility standards throughout. An open-source release of the platform core, accompanied by full technical

documentation, is planned at month 12 to support replication by other EDIHs across the EU. WP2 is time-bounded to months 1–12 to ensure the platform is fully operational before the first training cohort launches in WP3 at month 6.

T2.1: Platform architecture and technical specifications - Define the federated platform architecture, including hub-level and central-level data models, role-based access control, GDPR-compliant data residency requirements, DSJP catalogue API integration specifications, and Europass EDCL connector design. Produce a technical specification document reviewed and approved by all consortium partners before development commences.

T2.2: Platform development and testing - Develop the LMS core, credential issuance module, DSJP catalogue connector, and hub-level customisation interfaces using an iterative, sprint-based development methodology. Conduct internal unit and integration testing followed by structured user acceptance testing with hub coordinators from all five EDIH partners, resolving all critical and major issues before the production release.

T2.3: Open-source release and documentation - Release the platform source code under an OSI-approved open licence via a public repository. Publish comprehensive technical documentation covering installation, configuration, hub customisation, DSJP integration, and EDCL connector setup, enabling any EDIH or national skills body to independently deploy the platform. Provide a recorded deployment walkthrough as part of the replication guide contributed to D5.3.

WP3: Training Delivery and Hub Operations

Lead: EDIH Spain | Person-months: 88 | Duration: M6 - M36

WP3 constitutes the operational heart of AISKILLS-EU, managing the end-to-end delivery of training across all five academy hubs from month 6 through the project close. Hub coordinators are responsible for SME outreach and participant recruitment, cohort scheduling and management, trainer facilitation, completion rate monitoring, and structured learner feedback collection. The three delivery modalities — self-paced e-learning, live virtual cohorts, and in-person bootcamps at EDIH premises — are deployed in parallel to accommodate the diverse time, connectivity, and prior-skills profiles of SME workforces. Rolling training cycles are maintained throughout the delivery period to ensure a continuous pipeline of completions toward the 5,000-trainee target. The Financial Support to Third Parties (FSTP) mechanism is administered within WP3 to remove financial barriers for micro-enterprises, with a dedicated FSTP budget managed in compliance with Digital Europe Programme rules.

T3.1: Hub setup and trainer preparation - Establish full academy operations at each EDIH hub, including onboarding of local facilitators, training of SME outreach officers in programme messaging and enrolment procedures, configuration of hub-level platform customisation, and preparation of in-person bootcamp facilities. Deliver a train-the-trainer programme ensuring all facilitators are proficient in the three curriculum tiers and the platform's learner management tools.

T3.2: Cohort delivery (rolling cycles) - Execute rolling training cohorts across all five hubs beginning at month 6, targeting a minimum of 400 completions per semester across the hub network. Each cohort cycle encompasses all three delivery modalities; cohort scheduling is staggered across hubs to distribute platform load and enable cross-hub peer interaction where learner consent is obtained. Learner feedback is collected via standardised end-of-cohort surveys and fed into the WP1 quality assurance cycle.

T3.3: Financial support to third parties (FSTP) - Administer FSTP grants to eligible micro-enterprises to offset participation costs, in accordance with a published award criteria document approved at month 4. Manage the full FSTP cycle — open calls for applications, eligibility assessment, award decisions, monitoring of supported participants' completion, and financial reporting to HaDEA — ensuring transparency, equal access, and audit compliance throughout.

WP4: Certification and Credentialing

Lead: Training SME Germany | Person-months: 30 | Duration: M6 - M36

WP4 designs, implements, and operates the AISKILLS-EU micro-credential and certification scheme, providing learners with portable, digitally verifiable evidence of their AI competences. Micro-credentials are issued as Europass Digital Credentials for Learning (EDCL), ensuring compliance with the Council Recommendation on a European approach to micro-credentials and enabling cross-border recognition by employers and educational institutions. WP4 maintains a searchable, publicly accessible credential registry disaggregated by curriculum tier and country, providing transparency for employers and supporting labour-market uptake. National recognition activities engage qualifications authorities and employer associations in all five countries to build confidence in and demand for AISKILLS-EU credentials among hiring managers and HR professionals.

T4.1: Certification framework and assessment design - Design the assessment instruments, pass/fail criteria, and certification metadata for each curriculum tier, ensuring alignment with Europass EDCL technical requirements and the European Qualifications Framework (EQF). Document the certification framework in D4.1, including the appeals procedure, re-assessment policy, and quality oversight process overseen by the WP1 quality assurance committee.

T4.2: Credential issuance and registry management - Issue Europass Digital Credentials to all learners who successfully complete assessments, using the platform's integrated EDCL issuance module. Maintain a publicly searchable credential registry, updated monthly, providing employers with a verification mechanism. Report credential issuance volumes disaggregated by tier, country, and gender in each periodic progress report.

T4.3: National recognition and employer engagement - Engage national qualifications authorities, Europass National Centres, and employer associations in all five participating countries from month 6 onwards to promote formal or informal recognition of AISKILLS-EU credentials in recruitment and HR practice. Establish at least one employer advisory board per hub; produce a national recognition mapping document per country included in D4.1.

WP5: Dissemination, Communication and Sustainability

Lead: EDIH Poland | Person-months: 28 | Duration: M1 - M36

WP5 manages all communication, dissemination, and financial sustainability activities throughout the project lifetime. It produces and implements the project communication plan, manages the project website and social media presence, coordinates the upload of validated training modules to the DSJP catalogue, and maintains active liaison with the ELEVATE coordination structure and its joint dissemination workstreams. Critically, WP5 owns the sustainability function: from month 18 it works with each EDIH partner to develop, stress-test, and finalise a financially grounded hub-level sustainability plan, securing confirmed continuation commitments before the final payment request. The federated replication guide produced in WP5 enables other EDIHs across the EU to adopt the AISKILLS-EU model without requiring direct consortium involvement.

T5.1: Communication plan and brand development - Produce a comprehensive project communication plan (D5.1) covering: visual identity and branding standards; key messages differentiated by target audience (policymakers, EDIH ecosystem, SMEs and learners); channel strategy and editorial calendar; gender-inclusive communication guidelines; and a crisis communication protocol. Launch the project website and social media channels (LinkedIn, X/Twitter) within month 2; maintain active content publication throughout the project.

T5.2: DSJP catalogue contributions and ELEVATE liaison - Manage the submission, metadata tagging, and upload of AISKILLS-EU training modules to the Digital Skills and Jobs Platform training catalogue, targeting 30 modules by month 30. Maintain active participation in ELEVATE coordination calls, contributing to joint position papers, shared dissemination events, and the ELEVATE quality seal peer review process. Represent AISKILLS-EU at a minimum of six major European digital skills events over the project lifetime.

T5.3: Sustainability planning and post-grant model - Develop per-hub sustainability plans from month 18, incorporating revenue forecasts, identified national and EU co-funding streams, and a tiered pricing model for post-grant training delivery. Validate plans with each EDIH partner by month 22 and submit consolidated D5.3 at month 24. Secure written continuation commitments from all five EDIH partners — specifying projected trainee volumes and named funding sources — as a prerequisite for the final payment request. Publish the federated replication guide as an open-access resource for other EDIHs.

WP6: Project Management and Coordination

Lead: Digital Skills Agency Ireland (Coordinator) | Person-months: 24 | Duration: M1 - M36

WP6 provides the governance, financial management, risk oversight, and reporting framework that keeps AISKILLS-EU on track throughout its 36-month lifetime. It establishes and operates the Project Management Board (PMB), the Steering Committee, and the Ethics Advisory Panel. The PMB meets monthly in the first six months and quarterly thereafter; the Steering Committee meets biannually to provide strategic direction; and the Ethics Advisory Panel reviews the project's gender and inclusion performance, ethical AI curriculum content, and FSTP equity outcomes at months 12 and 30. WP6 prepares all periodic and final technical and financial reports to HaDEA, coordinates audit-readiness across all partners, and maintains the risk register with quarterly reviews and documented corrective actions.

T6.1: Governance setup and consortium coordination - Establish all governance bodies within month 2: convene the inaugural PMB meeting, constitute the Steering Committee with one senior representative per partner, and appoint the Ethics Advisory Panel with at least two external independent members. Maintain an up-to-date Consortium Agreement, internal communication protocols, and a shared document management system accessible to all partners.

T6.2: Financial management and reporting - Manage all financial flows between HaDEA and consortium partners in compliance with Digital Europe Programme grant agreement conditions. Prepare periodic financial statements consolidating partner cost claims; monitor expenditure against budget allocations and flag deviations exceeding 10% to the PMB. Coordinate audit-readiness activities across all partners, including maintenance of supporting documentation and preparation for any HaDEA audit or review.

T6.3: Risk monitoring and adaptive management - Maintain a live risk register covering technical, operational, financial, and external risks. Convene quarterly risk review meetings with WP leads; classify and update risk likelihood and impact ratings; and document and implement corrective actions within agreed response timeframes. Escalate risks rated high impact and medium or above likelihood to the Steering Committee for strategic decision-making.

3.2 Consortium Composition

Organisation	Country	Type	Role	Description
Digital Skills Agency Ireland	Ireland	Public national agency	Coordinator	Project coordinator; WP1 and WP6 lead; overall scientific, financial, and administrative responsibility
EDIH Spain	Spain	European Digital Innovation Hub	Partner	WP3 lead (training delivery); regional SME outreach in Spain and southern Europe
EDIH Poland	Poland	European Digital Innovation Hub	Partner	WP5 lead (dissemination and sustainability); training delivery in Poland and CEE region
EDIH Finland	Finland	European Digital Innovation Hub	Partner	WP2 lead (federated platform); technical architecture and open-source release
AI Training SME	Germany	Private SME — training and certification provider	Partner	WP4 lead (certification and credentialing); curriculum content development

The AISKILLS-EU consortium has been deliberately composed to cover the complete value chain of a large-scale federated skills academy, combining complementary and non-overlapping expertise in a configuration that no single organisation could replicate alone.

The coordinator, Digital Skills Agency Ireland, brings national policy authority, coordination capability at the EU level, and established relationships with HaDEA and the DSJP editorial board, providing the governance credibility and administrative rigour required for a Coordination and Support Action of this scale. The three EDIH partners — in Spain, Poland, and Finland — represent geographically and economically diverse SME ecosystems: Spain and southern Europe, Poland and the central-eastern European region, and Finland and the Nordic context. These contrasting national environments — with differing SME digital maturity profiles, language requirements, and national digital skills policy landscapes — ensure that the federated model is genuinely stress-tested across diverse contexts, greatly enhancing the replicability of the approach across the full EU. EDIH Finland's established technical infrastructure capacity leads the platform work package, while EDIH Spain's extensive SME client network anchors the highest-volume training delivery work package. The private-sector specialist partner, AI Training SME Germany, contributes deep operational expertise in assessment design, micro-credential issuance, and employer-facing certification — expertise that public EDIH nodes do not typically hold in-house — and leads the certification work package that is critical to the

project's long-term credibility with employers and qualifications authorities.

All five partners hold active EU Digital Europe or Horizon Europe project experience, have established working relationships with their national qualifications authorities and SME support networks, and are embedded in the EDIH coordination structure. The geographic footprint of five Member States across western, northern, and central-eastern Europe maximises both the project's direct reach and the cross-border replication potential of its outputs, ensuring a material contribution to EU-wide coverage of advanced AI skills for SME workforces.

3.3 Milestones

ID	Title	WP	Due	Verification
MS1	Consortium Agreement signed and governance bodies operational	WP6	M2	Signed Consortium Agreement submitted to HaDEA; PMB meeting minutes
MS2	Needs analysis complete and curriculum framework approved	WP1	M6	D1.1 approved by Steering Committee and quality assurance committee
MS3	Federated platform deployed and integrated with DSJP	WP2	M12	Platform live URL; DSJP catalogue connector test report; D2.2 accepted
MS4	First training cohort completed across all five hubs	WP3	M14	Cohort completion records showing minimum 200 completions; learner feedback report
MS5	Certification scheme operational; first 500 credentials issued	WP4	M20	Credential registry extract; Europass EDCL issuance confirmation
MS6	Mid-term review: 2,500 trainees reached; sustainability plans drafted	WP5, WP6	M24	Mid-term progress report; per-hub sustainability plan drafts reviewed by PMB
MS7	5,000 trainees and 2,500 certifications achieved	WP3, WP4	M34	Platform completion database; certification registry; periodic report data
MS8	Project closed; all deliverables submitted; continuation confirmed	WP6	M36	Final report accepted; per-hub continuation confirmation letters

3.4 Deliverables

ID	Title	WP	Due	Type	Dissemination
D1.1	AISKILLS-EU Curriculum Framework and Module Catalogue	WP1	M8	Report	Public
D1.2	Quality Assurance Framework and	WP1	M12	Report	Public

	Seal Alignment Report				
D2.1	Federated Platform Technical Specifications	WP2	M6	Technical document	Public
D2.2	Federated Platform — Production Release and Open-Source Repository	WP2	M12	Software / open-source release	Public
D3.1	Hub Operations Manual and Trainer Guidelines	WP3	M8	Guidelines	Public
D3.2	Biannual Training Delivery Reports (x5)	WP3	M36	Progress report	Restricted (HaDEA)
D4.1	AISKILLS-EU Certification Framework and Assessment Instruments	WP4	M10	Report	Public
D4.2	Annual Credential Registry Reports (x3)	WP4	M36	Data report	Public
D5.1	Communication and Dissemination Plan	WP5	M3	Plan	Public
D5.2	Annual Market Intelligence Report on AI Skills for SMEs (x3)	WP5	M36	Report	Public
D5.3	Per-Hub Sustainability Plans and Federated Replication Guide	WP5	M24	Report / Guide	Public
D6.1	Data Management Plan	WP6	M3	Plan	Restricted (HaDEA)
D6.2	Periodic and Final Technical and Financial Reports	WP6	M36	Progress / Final report	Restricted (HaDEA)

3.5 Resources and Budget Summary

Cost Category	Amount (EUR)
Personnel Costs	3800000
Subcontracting	600000
Travel & Subsistence	180000
Equipment	120000
Other Direct Costs	480000
Indirect Costs (25%)	820000
TOTAL	6000000

--	--

3.6 Risk Management

ID	Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
R1	Lower-than-expected SME enrolment due to competing demands on staff time and low awareness of the programme	Medium	High	Dedicated SME outreach officers at each EDIH hub; FSTP grants to reduce financial barriers; flexible scheduling (self-paced and evening cohorts); engagement through existing EDIH SME client bases from month 1
R2	Platform adoption barriers — SME staff unfamiliar with online learning environments or experiencing connectivity constraints	Medium	Medium	In-person bootcamp track as alternative to fully online delivery; accessible platform design (WCAG 2.1 AA); multilingual interface; digital literacy pre-module included in AI Literacy tier
R3	Consortium partner capacity shortfall — key personnel leave or EDIH operational priorities shift	Low	High	Consortium Agreement includes personnel replacement clauses; cross-training of WP deputies at each partner; PMB reviews resource allocation quarterly
R4	Certification recognition barriers — employers or national authorities do not recognise Europass micro-credentials issued by the project	Medium	Medium	Early engagement with national qualifications authorities (T4.3 from month 6); employer advisory board established at each hub; alignment with existing national certification frameworks documented in D4.1
R5	Platform integration failure — DSJP catalogue API or Europass EDCL connector not available or changes during the project	Low	Medium	Technical risk mitigated by early API prototyping (T2.1, month 2); fallback: manual catalogue submission process; regular liaison with DSJP technical team
R6	Financial sustainability post-grant not achieved at one or more hubs	Medium	High	Sustainability plans developed from month 18 (WP5); continuation commitments

				required at MS6 (month 24); diversified revenue model (EDIH core budget, national funding, fee-based tracks for larger SMEs) documented per hub
--	--	--	--	---

DRAFT